



**I F JAY GATSBY**—from F. Scott Fitzgerald’s fictional world of West Egg in *The Great Gatsby*—was transported

to Mumbai, his parties would end not with champagne toasts but with the clink of crystal tumblers filled with smoky, tropically matured Indian single malt.

The rise of Indian single malt over the last few years has also seen the creation of a market for personalised whiskey casks. These bespoke casks have become the ultimate luxury, enticing collectors to commission one-of-a-kind single malts rather than just purchasing bottles or special editions.

From the balmy tropics of Goa, two alcoholic beverage (alco-bev) companies are leading this cask ownership revolution in India—Diageo India, with its India Rare Spirits programme, and John Distilleries, which has the Paul John Single Cask Program. From the uber luxury, invite-only offering from Diageo India to Paul John’s “approachable luxury” programme, this duo is bringing the best of single malts to the nation and the world.

“Globally, cask programmes have been around for a long time, and what we’re seeing in India is their natural expansion... They have the potential to do very well in India because of the purchasing power and the emotional connection people have with whiskey,” says Vikram Achanta, Founder & CEO of Tulleeho and Co-Founder of 30BestBarsIndia and India Bartender Week. According to Achanta, internationally, brands usually target about a 1% conversion rate for their cask programmes, but in India, they are aiming for 2–3%. “The motivations for ownership are very strong in this country, be it legacy, celebration, or exclusivity,” he says.

A collection of 13 types of wood and 70+ finishing casks from Diageo’s portfolio of Indian and Spanish distilleries lends a distinctive character to the

special casks distilled and matured in Ponda, the heart of Goa, where Diageo India bottles bespoke single malts. Currently, the invite-only programme allows the buyer to customise his cask of choice to formulate a one-of-a-kind creation.

When Diageo India introduced this programme, the intention was to elevate whiskey ownership into a celebration of artistry and heritage while catering to the exponential growth of luxury propositions in India. “The need for bespoke luxury propositions is growing. It’s no longer about buying into mass luxury but a proposition that is special, personalised and tailor-made for individuals. The trend is growing by the day,” says Vikram Damodaran, Chief Innovation Officer at Diageo India.

In south Goa, there is another distinctive distillery in Cuncolim, home to the award-winning Indian single malt Paul John and Paul John Single Cask Program. Currently, with close to

▼  
**DIAGEO**  
bottles single  
malts in India as  
part of its India  
Rare Spirits  
programme in  
Goa’s Ponda,  
where its casks  
are distilled and  
matured

